



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

Journey 3: Make Your Business Official

This is **Journey 03** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 3: Make Your Business Official

"Imagine Pick n Pay wants to buy your amagwinya tomorrow. Are you ready?"

Most big buyers, funders, and banks won't work with you until your business is official. This journey walks you through exactly what "official" means, one small step at a time. No lectures, just what to do next.

Why Bother Registering?

"You're already selling 100 plates a week from your yard. Why would you need any paperwork at all?"

Right now, you and your business are the same thing in the eyes of the law. If something goes wrong, it's your personal problem, not just "the business's" problem. Once you register, your business becomes its own thing, separate from you (Companies Act 71 of 2008). That's what opens the door to bank accounts, big contracts, and funding.

 **QUICK TIP** You don't have to register everything at once. Start with the one piece of paper that unlocks the most doors: your CIPC registration (next lesson).

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write down one thing you'd do differently if a big retailer called you tomorrow.

Complete this and earn:  "Getting Serious" badge

Let's Make It Official

"Someone asks: 'Is your business registered?' What do you actually say?"

CIPC (the Companies and Intellectual Property Commission) is where every South African business gets its legal ID (Companies Act 71 of 2008). You register online at cipc.co.za. Once you're registered, your business has its own name and its own legal identity, separate from you personally.

 **QUICK TIP** Keep your CIPC certificate saved as a photo on your phone. You'll need to show it again and again, for permits, for the bank, and for funders.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Go to cipc.co.za and check what documents you'll need before you start.

Complete this and earn:  "Officially Official" badge

Get Your Food Permit Sorted

"Could a health inspector actually shut you down tomorrow?"

Yes, if you don't have a Certificate of Acceptability (called a CoA), you are trading illegally, even if your food is amazing. This is a permit from your local municipality that proves your kitchen is safe. It's a legal requirement under Regulation R638 (R638 of 2018).

 **QUICK TIP** Your CoA is tied to YOU and YOUR exact spot. If you move stalls or change hands, you need a brand new one. It doesn't transfer.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Find your nearest municipal Environmental Health office and save the number in your phone.

Complete this and earn:  "Food Safe" badge

The Other Permits People Forget

"You've got your CoA. Are you actually fully legal now?"

Not quite. Most food businesses also need a separate Business Licence from the municipality, under the Businesses Act (Businesses Act 71 of 1991). If you cook from home, you may also need permission for your property to be used for business (called zoning). Using gas, or planning to sell alcohol? Add a Gas Certificate and a Liquor Licence to your list too.



 **QUICK TIP** Ask your municipality for a full permit checklist on your first visit. Most people find out about a missing permit one at a time, the hard way.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** List every permit you currently have, then circle the ones you're missing.

Complete this and earn:  **"Paper Trail Pro" badge**

Sorting Out Your Tax

"If your business made R50,000 last month, do you owe SARS anything?"

It depends on how much your business earns in a year. As of April 2026, you only have to register for VAT once you earn more than R2.3 million a year (SARS, Budget 2026 FAQs). If you earn less, a simpler system called Turnover Tax might work better for you, since it replaces several taxes with one easy calculation.

 **QUICK TIP** Don't guess your number. Check sars.gov.za or visit a SARS branch to see exactly where your business sits, since these thresholds get updated over time.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Add up roughly what your business made in the last 12 months, and compare it to R2.3 million.

Complete this and earn:  **"Tax Smart" badge**

From Side Hustle to Official Business

"You sell from a stall, a yard, or your kitchen table right now. How do you actually get to be fully legal?"

You don't have to do it all in one week. Most people go in this order: check your spot is zoned correctly, then register with CIPC, then apply for your Business Licence and Food Permit together (inspectors often check both at once), then sort out tax once you're properly trading. Since 2024, even spaza shops have had to register, so the government is watching this space more closely than before.

 **QUICK TIP** Pick ONE step to finish this week. Don't try to do everything at once.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Choose your next step, and put a date on it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Levelling Up" badge**

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — [gov.za](https://www.gov.za).
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — [cipc.co.za](https://www.cipc.co.za).
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — [nrsc.org.za](https://www.nrsc.org.za).
- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — [sars.gov.za](https://www.sars.gov.za).
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — [labour.gov.za](https://www.labour.gov.za).



- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — infoeregulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. cloudfusion.co.za.
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? [brandingmag](http://brandingmag.com).
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. [ikhokha](http://ikhokha.com).

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. *Harvard Business Review*, 92(1/2), 27.

